

**CZECH REPUBLIC****Capital city:** Prague**Area:** 30,450sq miles
(78,866 sq km)**Population:** 10,200,000**Official language:** Czech**Major religions:** Christian
72%, other 28%**Government:** Multiparty
democracy**Currency:** Czech koruna**Adult literacy rate:** 99%**Life expectancy:** 75 years**People per doctor:** 294**Televisions:** 447 per 1,000
people

CZECH REPUBLIC

AS CENTRAL EUROPE'S most industrialized country, the Czech Republic has a modern economy and a good standard of living. From 1918 until 1993, the Republic was part of the union forming Czechoslovakia. By the 1950s, Czechoslovakia was under Soviet control, but democratic elections in 1990 led to its peaceful split into two countries – the Czech Republic and Slovakia. Much of the Republic lies on a high, mountain-ringed plateau, and its people have a strong national identity.

The main
grain crops
are wheat,
and rye.



Bridges over the Vltava River in Prague

PRAGUE

Not far from the historic core of this ancient city, one of the most beautiful capitals in Europe, a booming commercial center has sprung up. The capital is now host to ever-increasing numbers of visitors, coming for both pleasure and business. However, as elsewhere in Central Europe, air pollution is a major problem. It is caused mainly by factories in the commercial quarter, and in the extensive industrial suburbs beyond.

AGRICULTURE

In contrast to Poland, most of the agricultural land in the Czech Republic is worked by large farms owned by the state or by cooperatives. But, as in Poland, the changeover from a communist to a capitalist economy has proved difficult for farmers as they fight to compete in an open "market economy." Czech farms are very productive, with the highest grain yields in Central Europe. A large proportion of this grain is fed to livestock, since the Republic concentrates on meat and milk production.

THEATER

It is extremely appropriate that the Czech Republic's first president, Vaclav Havel, was also a playwright, since this region has a powerful theatrical tradition that stretches back to the 13th century. Contributions in other areas of the arts, notably music, literature, and film, have come from this region as well.

The Smetana Concert Hall, in Prague, was named after a Czech composer.



Intricate, highly
decorated
glassware

**BOHEMIAN GLASS**

For centuries, the fine sands found in this region, once known as Bohemia, have been used for glassmaking. Medieval craftsmen were praised for their breathtaking stained-glass windows. Bohemian glass is renowned for its high quality and delicacy and is still made today.

The brewing process in the Czech Republic

INDUSTRY

Beer is one of the best-known products to come out of this highly industrialized country. Its centuries-old brewing traditions have created such famous brands as Pilsner, made in Plzen since 1925, and Budweiss. Industry in general has a long history here. As long ago as the 1200s, mountains were excavated for their rich mineral deposits, and mining is still a major employer. Other important industries produce vehicles, explosives, plastics, and textiles.



Budweiser Budvar is a well-known export.

Find out more

AIR POLLUTION: 114

GLASSMAKING: 112

NEW EUROPEAN COUNTRIES: 81

POLITICAL SYSTEMS: 270–271